



TOC COHORT REPORT · 2026–27

The Anatomy of a *Professional Community*

A data-led look at how, where, and why education professionals across South Asia are gathering inside one professional community.

357

MEMBERS

across 332 organisations

252

RENEWALS

74% renewal rate

105

NEW MEMBERS

just walked in

13

COUNTRIES

via your organisations

— PROLOGUE —

Four years of momentum

The headline is 357 members. The story is the rate at which the field has converged on this community — year after year, in less time, by choice.

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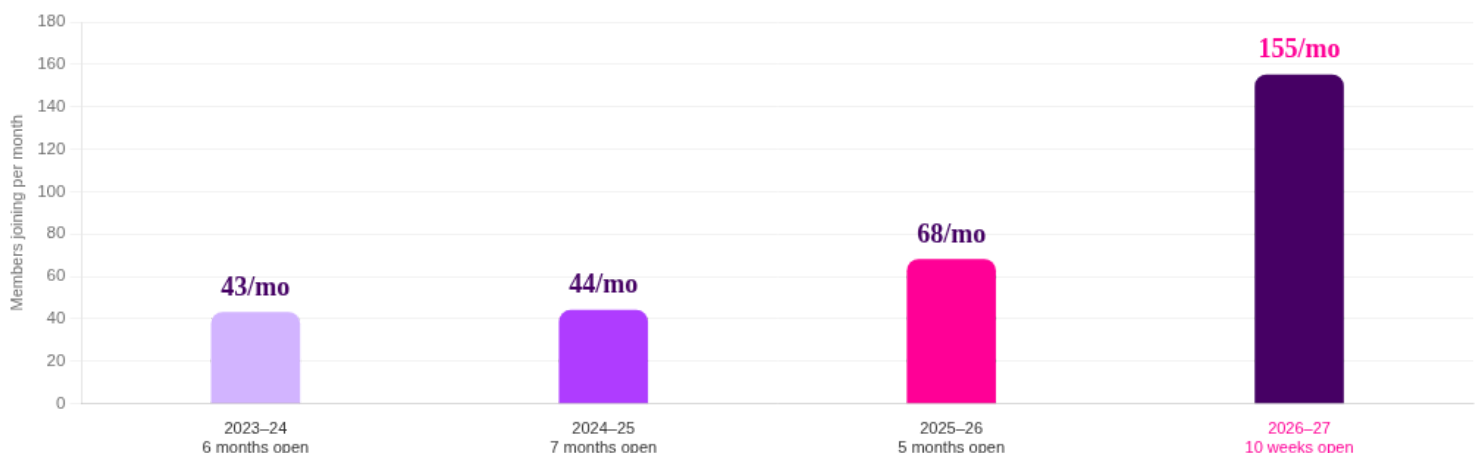
THE PREMISE OF THIS REPORT

The way education professionals in India develop themselves is changing — and until now, the scale of that change has been difficult to see.

This report examines what becomes visible when 357 senior practitioners across the field — counsellors, school leaders, university teams, IECs, founders, operators — choose to belong to the same professional community. The trajectory that brought them here is the first thing worth understanding.

THE ACQUISITION CURVE

Each bar is the rate at which members joined that year. The window kept shrinking. The rate kept climbing.



THE ACCELERATION

3.6×

faster acquisition rate than Year One

From ~43 new members per month in 2023-24 to ~155 per month this year — in a window less than half as long.

YEAR ON YEAR

2023–24 6 months open	259
2024–25 7 months open	308
2025–26 5 months open	339
2026–27 10 weeks open	357

More members. Less time. Year after year. The acquisition curve doesn't just chart a community growing — it charts a *field consolidating*.

ON MOMENTUM

WHAT THE TRAJECTORY TELLS US

In Year One, six months were needed to gather 259 members. This year, 357 joined in roughly ten weeks. The window has shrunk every cycle; the cohort has grown every cycle. That gap — between how long the doors stay open and how many professionals walk through them — is a signal of where this community has come to sit in the field. The decision to join isn't being deferred. **When the door opens, the room fills.**

— I —

The shape of the room

Three numbers, taken together, describe how this community gets built — and what kind of professional commitment it represents.

A 74% renewal rate isn't a metric. It's a *verdict* rendered, year after year, by people who could have spent the money elsewhere.

ON RETENTION

THE COMPOSITION STORY

Three independent decisions that say the same thing.

74%

Renewed from last year

70%

Pay for membership themselves

70%

Heard about TOC from a peer

WHAT THIS MEANS

Three independent decisions, each made privately, each pointing in the same direction. Members are **renewing voluntarily, paying out of their own pockets, and recommending TOC to peers**. No professional body acquires, retains, and gets recommended at these rates without

earning it — each metric individually is a strong signal; together, they describe a community that has shifted from optional to embedded in the professional lives of its members.

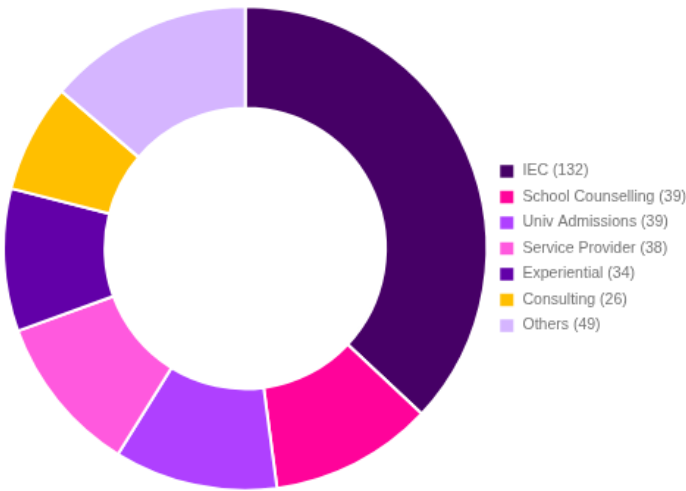
— II —

The composition of the field

What makes this room distinct isn't any single segment — it's the configuration. Counsellors, admissions teams, and providers operate in adjacent worlds; here, they operate in the same one.

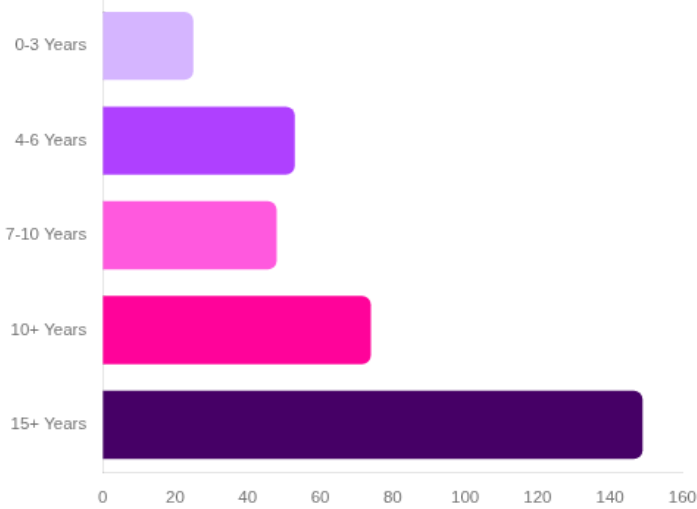
PRIMARY ROLE

No single segment owns the room.



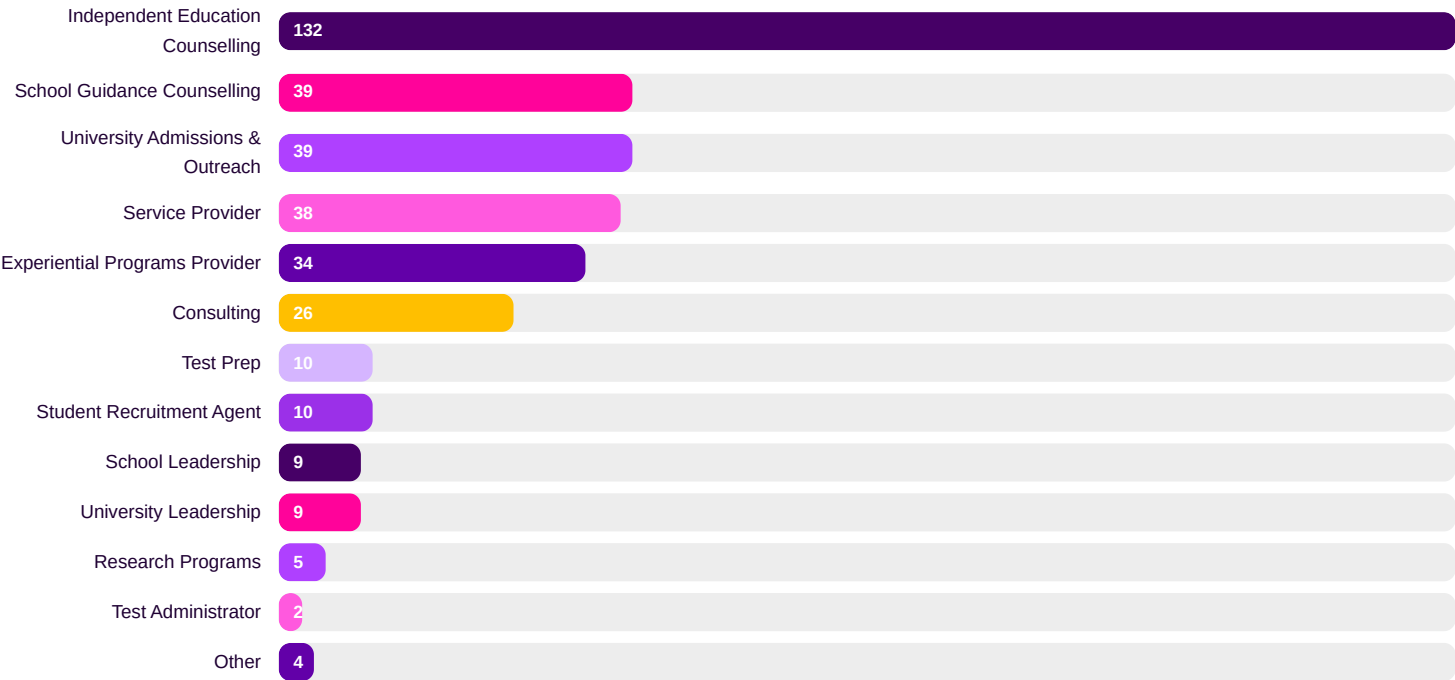
YEARS IN EDUCATION

A mid-career-to-senior community.



THE FULL SPREAD

Every category, every count.



WHY THIS MIX MATTERS

IECs at 37% (132 members) represent the largest concentration of Independent Education Counsellors in any Indian membership body, by a significant margin. The next five segments — **School Counselling (11%), University Admissions (11%), Service Provider (11%), Experiential Programs (10%), Consulting (7%)** — make up another 49% of the room. The result is a configuration unusual in this field: when an IEC raises a question, a school counsellor, a university outreach head, and a provider can all answer from their position in the value chain. **64% of the cohort has 10+ years of experience** — this is a senior room, and the conversation is calibrated accordingly.

THE SENIORITY OF THE ROOM

Members by leadership designation.

137

Founders & Co-Founders

70

Directors

74%

in senior leadership roles overall

WHO DECIDES WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

137 founders and co-founders. 70 directors. Add CEOs, Principals, Heads of Practice, and Chairs — and nearly three quarters of this cohort holds a senior leadership designation in their organisation. These are the people in education who set agendas, sign budgets, and shape how their institutions and businesses engage with the field. The conversations happening in this community are conversations between decision-makers.

A SELECTION OF MEMBER ORGANISATIONS

Representative of the 331 organisations from which TOC's 2026-27 cohort is drawn.

PREMIER INDIAN SCHOOLS

The Shri Ram School · Aditya Birla World Academy · Mayo College · Daly College · Aga Khan Academy Hyderabad · Shiv Nadar School · Greenwood High International School · Jamnabai Narsee School · Oberoi International School · Indus International School Bangalore · The American Embassy School · The Heritage School

INDIAN UNIVERSITIES & HIGHER EDUCATION INSTITUTIONS

Ashoka University · Krea University · FLAME University · Plaksha University · BML Munjal University · Shiv Nadar University · Ahmedabad University · CEPT University · SP Jain Group · Masters' Union · Imarticus · Universal AI University

GLOBAL UNIVERSITIES

University of Sydney · University of Exeter · The University of Tokyo · Hult International Business School · Fordham University · Loyola Marymount University · School of Visual Arts, New York · New York Film Academy · Bocconi · Leeds Arts University · Singapore Institute of Management · Pennsylvania College of Technology

ESTABLISHED EDUCATION COMPANIES & PLATFORMS

The Chopras · The Red Pen · Collegepond · Jamboree Education · Cialfo · Mindler · CollegeBoard · MSM Unify · Yocket · ForeignAdmits · upGrad · Acumen (Sannam S4 Group) · The Innovation Story · Sparkl Edventure · Creya Learning · Polygence · Maker's Asylum · Affairs Exhibitions & Media · FRR Forex · Austrade · Gresham Global Consultancy · Kruu

WHY THIS MATTERS

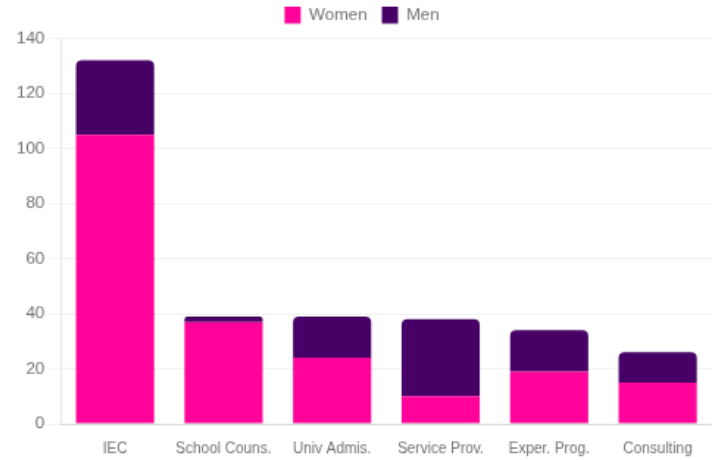
The names above represent a fraction of the 331 organisations from which this cohort is drawn — selected for recognisability rather than completeness. Read together, they describe the breadth of institutional weight present in the community: India's most established K-12 schools, its emerging university ecosystem, the universities that Indian students apply to internationally, and the companies building the infrastructure of education in this region. **The room is configured for the senior decision-makers of these organisations to meet each other** — and to meet the independent practitioners advising the families and students they all serve.

The community is 65% women — but the variation across professional segments is where the more interesting pattern sits.

GENDER SPLIT



BY PROFESSIONAL SEGMENT



WHAT STANDS OUT

School Counselling is **95% women**. IECs are **80% women**. Service Providers are **74% men**. These distributions reflect the structure of the broader education industry — counselling roles skew female; service and vendor roles skew male. The configuration is unremarkable in isolation; what's notable is that very few professional spaces in this sector bring these segments into the same room. TOC is one of the few that does.

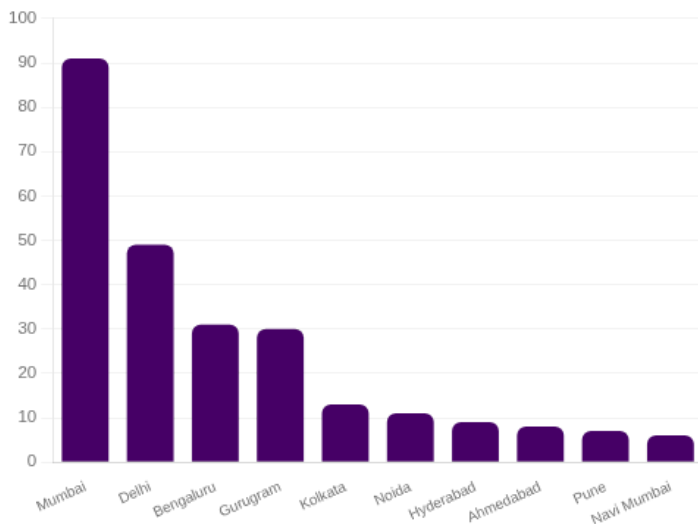
— IV —

Geographic footprint

India-anchored, internationally connected. The geographic spread tells its own story about where serious education work is happening across South Asia and beyond.

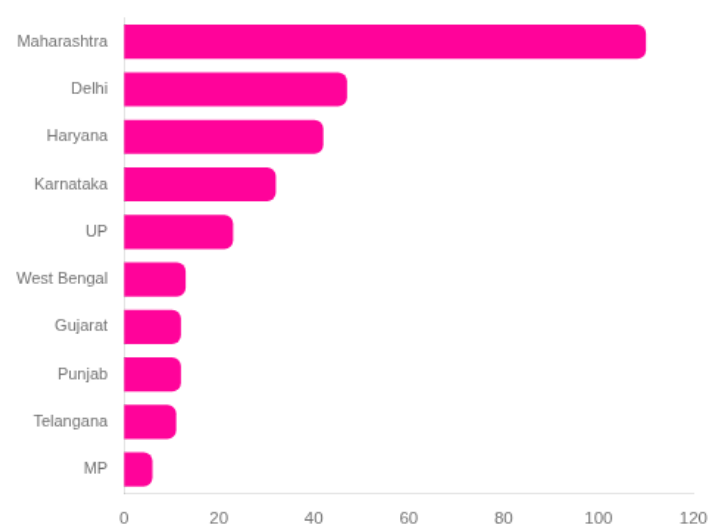
TOP CITIES

Where you live and work.



BY STATE

India's education map, TOC edition.



THE INTERNATIONAL LAYER

Where your organisations are headquartered. 13 countries beyond India.

13 USA 5 UAE 3 Australia 3 Singapore 3 Luxembourg 3 Canada 2 UK 1 France 1 Italy 1 Germany 1 Japan

READING THE MAP

56% of members are concentrated in four cities — Mumbai, Delhi, Gurugram, Bengaluru — the dominant centres for India's outbound and inbound education work. Beyond the metro core, the community has meaningful presence in Kolkata, Hyderabad, Pune, Ahmedabad, and across Tier 2 hubs including Indore, Lucknow, Dehradun, Chandigarh and Jalandhar. The international layer is built through member organisations: 13 countries represented, with university admissions teams from **USA, Australia, France, Italy, Singapore, Canada, the UK and Japan**. The "South Asia" descriptor understates the actual reach.

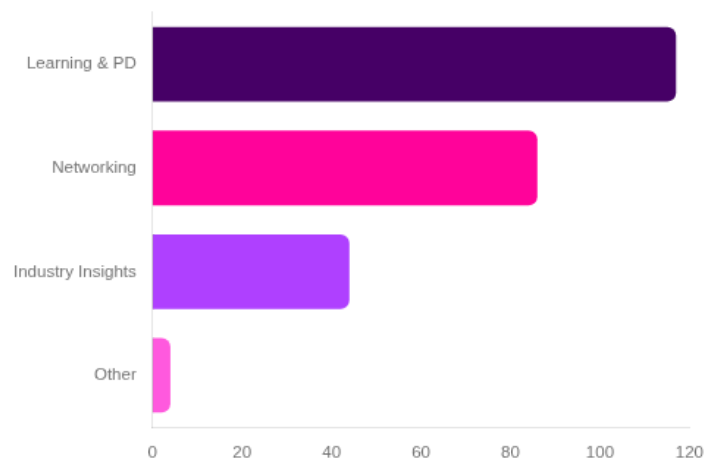
— V —

What members come for

The reasons given for joining and the reasons given for renewing are not the same — and the gap between them tells us something about what depth in a professional community actually delivers.

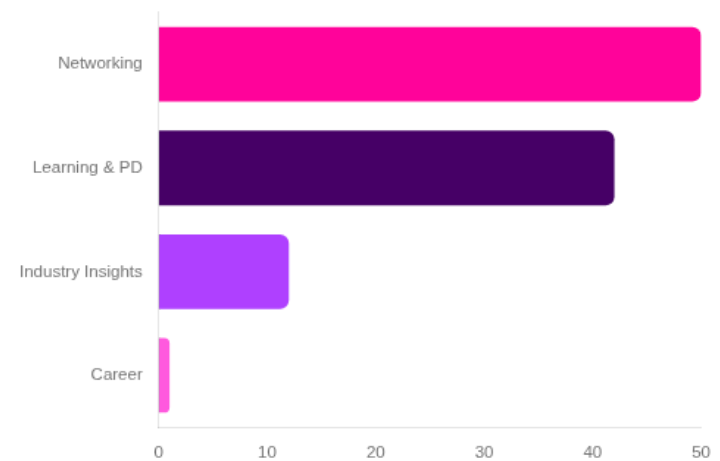
WHY RENEWING MEMBERS STAYED

252 members chose to come back.



WHY NEW MEMBERS JOINED

105 members chose to walk in.



New members come for networking. Renewing members stay for learning. The same community is being valued for *different things* at different stages of belonging.

ON WHAT DEPTH DELIVERS

THE PATTERN

For new members, **"Networking" is the dominant reason to join (48%)**. For renewing members, **"Learning & Professional Development" is the dominant reason to stay (47%)**. What looks like a contradiction is actually a sequence: networking is what brings education professionals through the door; structured peer learning is what holds them. A community that grows on the first promise and retains on the second has earned a deeper place in members' professional lives than the entry transaction suggests.

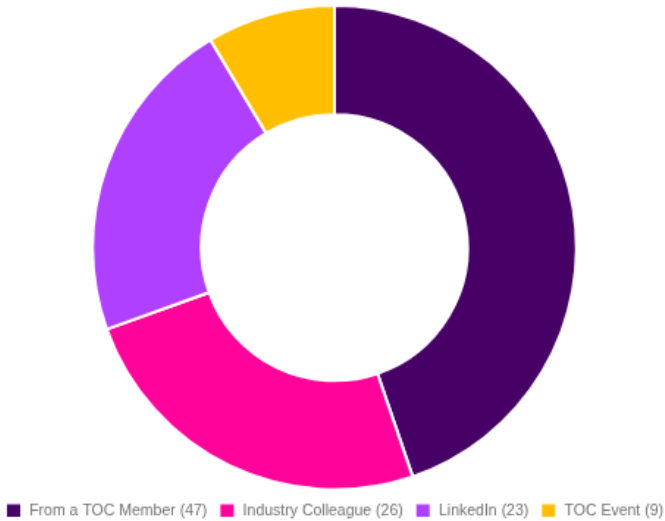
— VI —

How the field finds itself

The acquisition pattern reveals more than how new members arrive. It reveals how the community is positioned in the professional networks of those who already trust it.

FIRST TOUCH — NEW MEMBER ACQUISITION

Where the 105 new members heard about TOC.



THE REFERRAL ENGINE

70%

of new members came through a TOC member or industry colleague

TRANSLATION

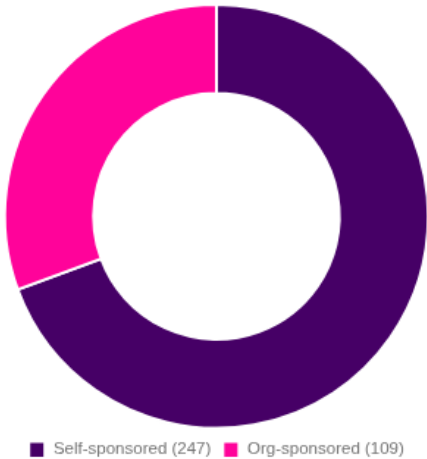
47 of this year's 105 new members were referred by an existing TOC member. Another 26 came through industry colleagues. Only 23 came through LinkedIn. Communities that grow by personal recommendation grow slower than those that grow by reach — and they grow with members who arrive already vouched for. That changes the quality of the room, not just the size of it.

— VII —

How members invest in this community

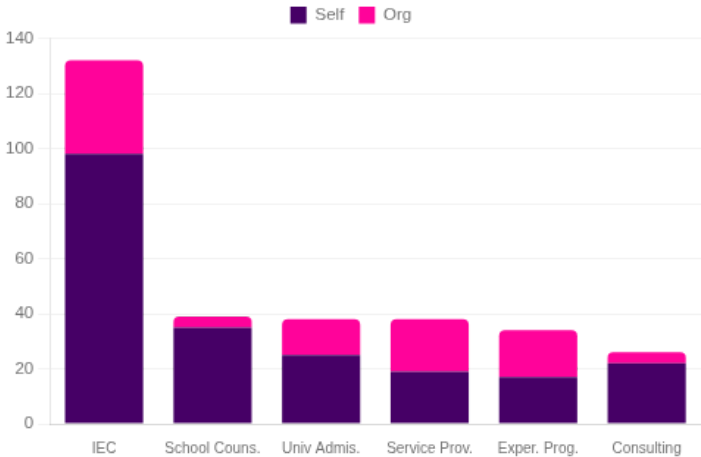
70% of members pay for membership themselves. That number tells a story about the field — and the 2.5× growth in organisational sponsorship this year tells another.

SELF-SPONSORED VS ORG-SPONSORED



BY SEGMENT

Where institutional budgets are deployed.



THE INSTITUTIONAL SIGNAL

Year-on-year change in organisation-sponsored memberships.

2.5×

growth in org-sponsored memberships YoY

2025–26
org-sponsored

44

2026–27
org-sponsored

109

WHAT SPONSORSHIP PATTERNS REVEAL

The dominant story across this cohort is personal investment. **School Counsellors (90% self), Consulting (85% self), Schools overall (90% self), IECs (74% self)** — across segment after segment, education professionals in India are paying for their own development because the institutions they work in haven't structured budgets for non-academic PD. That isn't a TOC observation; it's a **structural feature of the Indian education sector**. What this report makes visible is the scale of that personal commitment when a credible community exists for it to flow into. The encouraging counter-signal is institutional: **organisation-sponsored memberships have grown from 44 last year to 109 this year — a 2.5× jump**. Schools, universities, and education companies are starting to recognise what their teams already know.

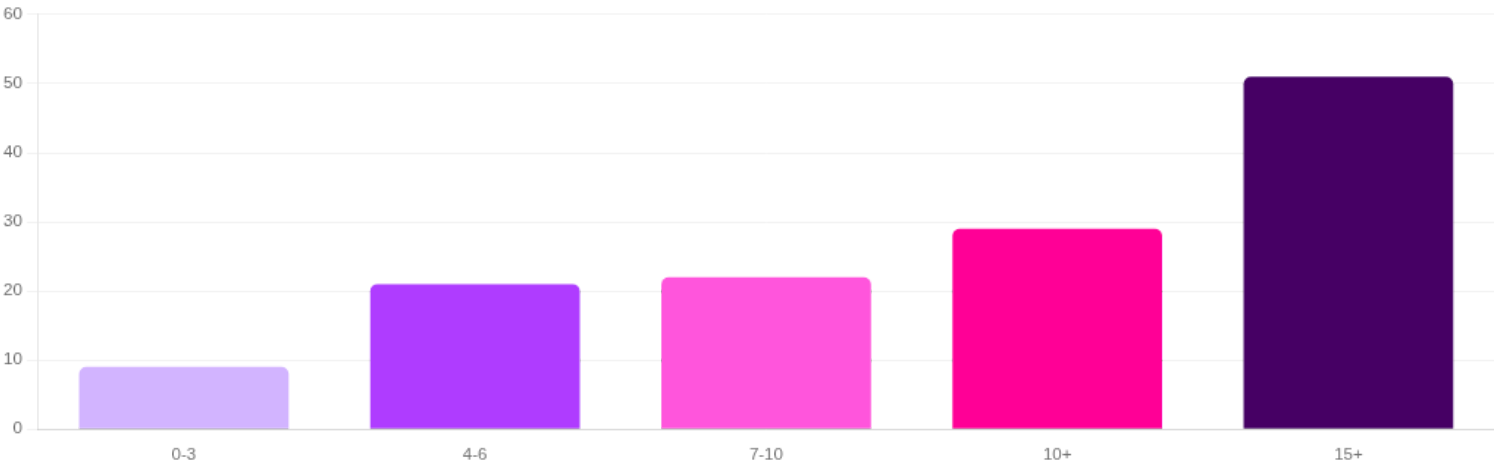
— VIII —

A closer look: the IEC bench

132 Independent Education Counsellors. The largest concentrated IEC community in any Indian professional body, by a wide margin. The composition warrants a closer read.

IEC EXPERIENCE DISTRIBUTION

A senior bench — 60%+ have a decade or more in education.



THE IEC PROFILE

80% women. 61% with 10+ years of experience. 74% paying themselves. A senior, self-funded segment — the kind of profile a peer-learning community needs at its core. These aren't isolated practitioners seeking visibility; they are established professionals who've added TOC to professional lives that already include institutional commitments, client work, and other affiliations. When IECs renew, they renew with their wallets — and at this scale, that pattern signals where the gravitational centre of independent counselling in India now sits.

— IX —

A closer look: the Experiential Learning bench

India's experiential learning sector is young, founder-led, and accelerating. 34 of its leaders are members of TOC — and the way they engage tells a particular story.

INSTITUTIONAL INVESTMENT

50%

THE EXPERIENTIAL COHORT

Composition of the segment.

Total members	34
Women / Men	19 / 15

org-sponsored — half of the segment is funded by the companies its founders run

Experiential learning founders are not just paying for membership themselves — they're putting their *companies'* budgets behind it.

10+ years experience

~65%

Org-sponsored

50%

For an emerging category like experiential learning, the question isn't where the founders network — it's where the *category itself* is being shaped.

ON INDUSTRY FORMATION

WHY THIS MATTERS

Experiential learning in India is in the formative phase — a sector where definitions, standards, and professional norms are still being negotiated in real time. With 34 founders and senior leaders represented, TOC has become the **largest professional platform for India's experiential learning category**. Half of these members are sponsored by the very companies they founded — a pattern that signals these aren't founders here on the margins of their schedules. They're underwriting their teams' membership because they recognise that the conversations shaping the next phase of the industry are happening here. That's a different proposition than peer learning; it's category formation.

— x —

A closer look: the schools bench

49 educators from across school structures — counsellors, leaders, and faculty. The most striking feature isn't who they are. It's how they're paying.

PERSONAL INVESTMENT, INSTITUTIONAL REALITY

86%

self-sponsored — even though every member here works inside a school

Schools employ these professionals. Schools rarely fund their professional development beyond academic training. The bill is being paid out of personal income.

THE SCHOOLS COHORT

Composition across the school structure.

Total members

56

Counsellors / Leaders / Faculty

42 / 10 / 4

10+ years experience

~77%

Self-sponsored

86%

When school staff pay for their own professional development, the institution learns something it didn't budget to learn: that *the appetite was always there*.

ON THE SCHOOLS LAYER

WHY THIS MATTERS

Most Indian schools allocate professional development budgets for academic faculty — pedagogy training, curriculum workshops, subject upskilling. Counsellors, school leaders, and non-academic staff often fall outside that allocation. The schools bench at TOC is the consequence of that gap. **86% of school-affiliated members fund their membership themselves**, even when their institutions could do so. That is not a complaint about budgets.

It's a signal that Indian school professionals are willing to invest in their own development at scale — and that the institutional decision to underwrite it would simply meet a demand that is already organised, already engaged, and already paying.

— XI —

A closer look: the universities bench

49 members from university admissions, leadership, and faculty — representing institutions across eight countries. This is where the global layer of the community is most concretely visible.

AN INTERNATIONAL BENCH

29%

represent universities headquartered outside India

From the United States, Australia, the UK, France, Italy, Singapore, Canada, and Japan — TOC sits inside the same room as the universities Indian students are applying to.

THE UNIVERSITIES COHORT

Composition across roles.

Total members 49

Admissions / Leadership / Faculty 39 / 9 / 1

10+ years experience ~75%

Outside India 14 / 49

South Asia is the largest source of internationally mobile students in the world. TOC is one of the few places where the universities receiving them sit in the *same room* as the counsellors sending them.

ON THE INTERNATIONAL LAYER

WHY THIS MATTERS

The universities bench is the most globally distributed segment of the cohort. Of 49 members, **14 represent universities headquartered outside India** — across the United States, Australia, the United Kingdom, France, Italy, Singapore, Canada and Japan. The remaining 35 represent Indian universities. That configuration matters. India remains the largest source of internationally mobile students globally, and the conversation that determines how those students are reached, advised, and supported runs through people in this segment. TOC is one of the few professional spaces where the institutions receiving Indian students and the professionals sending them belong to the same community.

— XII —

A closer look: the service providers bench

34 founders and senior operators of edtech, counselling tech, scholarship platforms, and the businesses serving the education ecosystem. The most evenly sponsored segment in the cohort.

EVENLY INVESTED

50/50

self-sponsored vs. organisation-sponsored — the most balanced split of any segment

THE SERVICE PROVIDERS COHORT

Composition of the segment.

Total members 34

Women / Men 8 / 26

For service providers, TOC functions both as personal professional development and as strategic access to the field they serve. The split shows it.

10+ years experience

~53%

Sponsorship split

17 / 17

For the operator, TOC is personal development. For the company, it is strategic access. The 50/50 sponsorship split is what happens when *both are true*.

ON THE PROVIDERS LAYER

WHY THIS MATTERS

This is the most male-skewed segment of the cohort (76% men) — consistent with the founder-and-senior-operator demographic that runs businesses serving the education sector. It is also the most evenly sponsored: **50% pay for membership themselves, 50% are sponsored by the companies they run or work for**. The split reflects a dual function. For the operator, TOC is personal professional development. For the company, it is strategic access to the field they serve. Few professional spaces are configured to hold both — the providers building the tools, platforms, and services for education sit in the same community as the practitioners using them. The presence of this bench, at this scale, completes the configuration of the cohort.

— XIII —

The professional home

Membership in another professional body is voluntary, costly, and considered. The patterns of who joins, who renews, and who chooses TOC alone reveal the position the community has come to occupy.

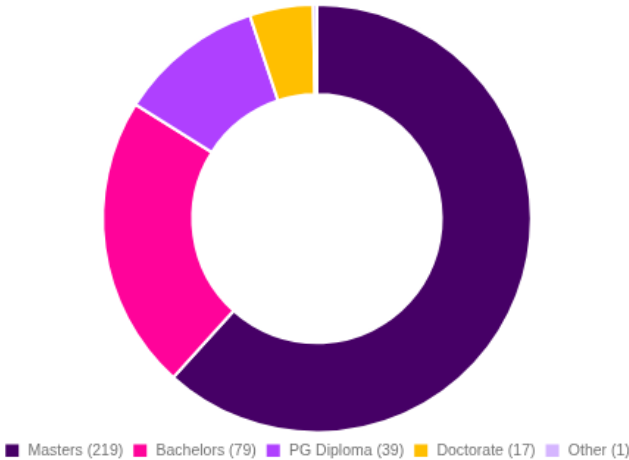
TOC-ONLY VS MULTI-ASSOCIATION

How members choose to engage professionally.



HIGHEST QUALIFICATION

A well-credentialed cohort.



75% of new members chose TOC as their *only* professional membership. People aren't adding TOC to a stack — they're picking it.

ON PREFERENCE

THE CHOICE PATTERN

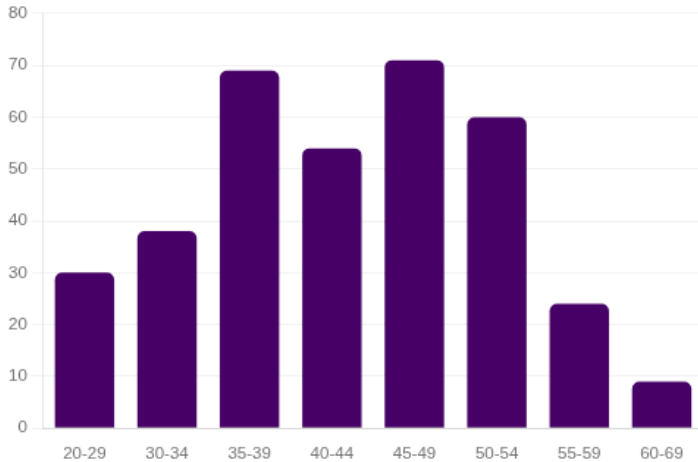
75%

of new members joined TOC as their **first and only** professional association

82%

of multi-association members **renewed** TOC — the highest renewal rate of any group

AGE DISTRIBUTION



A MID-CAREER COMMUNITY

43

Median age

72% of members are between 35 and 55 — at the peak of their professional influence, with the experience to contribute and the curiosity to keep learning.

READING BETWEEN THE LINES

Two patterns are worth holding together. **75% of new members joined with TOC as their only professional association** — they are not stacking memberships, they are choosing one. And among members who do hold other affiliations, **82% renewed** this year — the highest renewal rate of any segment in the cohort. Read together: education professionals entering the professional association space for the first time pick TOC. Those who have been around long enough to compare keep choosing it again. **From both ends of the experience curve, the same conclusion is being reached independently.**

— XIV —

What this report concludes

The premise this report opened with — that the way Indian education professionals develop themselves is changing, and the scale of that change has been hard to see — has now been examined across 13 sections. Three findings carry the weight of what the data shows.

01

Professional development in Indian education has shifted from institutional obligation to personal investment.

Across school counselling, school leadership, IEC practice, and consulting, the dominant funding pattern is self-sponsorship. Indian education professionals are bankrolling their own development at scale — not because budgets exist, but because they don't. This is a structural feature of the sector, and it is reorganising what professional development looks like in this region.

02

The collaborative perimeter of K-12 and higher education has expanded — and India is at the centre of that expansion.

School counsellors, school leaders, IECs, university admissions teams from eight countries, experiential learning founders, and the operators of the platforms serving them all belong to one cohort. That configuration does not exist elsewhere in this region at this scale. The data is anchored in India because India is the largest source of internationally mobile students globally — but the conversation it sustains is not bounded by India.

A new kind of professional infrastructure is taking shape in the Global South — and TOC is its fastest-growing instance.

357 members in ten weeks. A 3.6× acceleration in acquisition over four years. The largest concentrated IEC bench, the largest experiential learning leadership presence, and the highest renewal rate of any segment among multi-association members. These numbers describe a professional body that is no longer emerging but established — built differently, growing faster, and gathering a category of professionals that legacy associations were not configured to serve.

WHO THIS REPORT IS FOR

For education professionals across South Asia, the report is a portrait of the community they have built — and the patterns of behaviour that have built it.

For institutions and organisations seeking access to this market — universities recruiting Indian students, edtech and education companies entering the region, global education bodies tracking the South Asia trajectory — the report is a map. It identifies where the senior practitioners of the Indian education sector now gather, how they make professional decisions, and the channels through which credible engagement with this market increasingly runs.

The pulse of the field

This is what the data describes: a professional community that has shifted, in four years, from emerging to established. Built on personal investment. Configured for cross-segment dialogue. Anchored in India, reaching well beyond it.

Not by claim. By choice.

